

MAB2 Marketing Communication 2026
Exam Advice

SECTION 1: EXAM STRUCTURE AND WHAT YOU ARE TESTED ON

The Three Tasks

The exam paper will have three tasks. Task 1A and Task 1B are each worth 25 percent of the final grade. Task 2 is worth 50 percent.

Task 1A and Task 1B each present a short case description followed by structured sub-questions. The sub-questions name the frameworks you are expected to use. Your job is to apply those frameworks to the specific situation described, using the specific data provided in the case. The sub-questions are not invitations to write a general explanation of the framework. They are invitations to use the framework as a diagnostic tool on a concrete problem.

Task 2 is a campaign design task. You are given an organization with a specific budget, and asked to design a marketing communications campaign structured across eight sub-questions. Task 2 is graded with a big picture view, meaning the eight sub-questions are not scored individually. The grader reads the whole response and assesses it as a unified campaign.

The Four Grading Dimensions

Every task is graded on four dimensions. These four dimensions apply equally to Task 1 and Task 2. Understanding them precisely is the single most important thing you can do before the exam.

Dimension	What it actually means
Theory Application	You use frameworks accurately and connect them to the decisions you are making. Frameworks drive your analysis; they are not decorations added after you have already written your answer.
Case Analysis	You draw on the specific numbers, facts, and details given in the case. Generic observations that could apply to any company in any situation get no credit here.
Reasoning	Your argument is logically connected. Conclusions follow from evidence. You explain the mechanism, not just the outcome. You acknowledge trade-offs.

Clarity	Your response is organized, clearly labeled, and appropriately detailed across all parts of the question. No sub-question is left at one sentence while another gets three paragraphs.
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A response that knows all the theory but ignores the case data scores a C at best. A response that engages deeply with the case but misapplies frameworks also scores a C at best. You need all four to reach A or B.

What Each Grade Level Requires

The following describes what examiners are looking for at each level.

Grade	Theory Application	Case Analysis	Reasoning	Clarity
A	Frameworks used precisely and integrated with each other. Theory drives choices rather than decorating them.	Specific data points from the case cited to support every claim. Non-obvious connections identified.	A coherent argument built across the whole response. Trade-offs acknowledged. Mechanisms explained.	Professional structure. Each sub-question gets appropriate depth. The response reads as a unified whole.
B	Frameworks correctly applied and connected to the case. May rely heavily on one or two rather than integrating several.	Case details used to support most claims. May miss one connection or over-rely on a single data point.	Sound logic throughout. May lack one layer of depth in the chain of reasoning.	Clear and well-organized. Minor gaps in depth on one or two sub-questions.
C	Frameworks named and broadly	References the case but does not	Some reasoning present but	Adequate structure. Uneven

	correct but applied generically. The answer could describe almost any company, not specifically the one in the case.	consistently tie claims to specific data. Analysis stays at the surface.	arguments are asserted rather than built. Priorities stated without justification.	depth across sub-questions.
D	One or more frameworks misunderstood or partially incorrect. Theory feels tacked on rather than integrated.	Minimal engagement with case specifics. Case mentioned but not analyzed.	Weak logical connections. Recommendations feel arbitrary or contradictory.	Disorganized. Several sub-questions receive only a sentence or two.
F	Major conceptual errors throughout. Cannot distinguish between core concepts.	Ignores the case or makes claims contradicted by the data.	No coherent reasoning.	Incomplete or incoherent.

The single most important distinction in this table is between B and C. B-level answers apply frameworks correctly and connect them to the case. C-level answers describe frameworks correctly but apply them generically.

SECTION 2: APPLYING SOME MAJOR FRAMEWORKS

This section covers the frameworks that often appear across Task 1 and Task 2. For each framework, it explains what the examiner is looking for beyond a basic definition, what distinguishes a strong application from a weak one, and what common errors to avoid. Note that these are just some examples to illustrate good applications of frameworks.

DRIP

DRIP is the most frequently tested framework in Task 1. The four tasks are Differentiate, Reinforce, Inform, and Persuade. Every exam question that uses DRIP requires you to do three things, not one.

First, identify which task is the top priority for this organization, given the specific data provided. This is not a matter of personal preference. It follows from the case. Low unaided awareness means Inform must come before Reinforce, because you cannot reinforce recognition that does not yet exist. Inability to articulate differentiation means Differentiate must precede Persuade, because you cannot persuade someone to prefer a brand they cannot distinguish from competitors.

Second, explain why your chosen priority comes before the others. The DRIP framework has an implicit logic: some tasks are preconditions for others. Reinforce only works on customers who already know and have experience with the brand. Persuade is more efficient once differentiation is clear. A strong answer makes this sequencing explicit.

Third, connect every priority directly to specific case data. Do not say “the brand has low awareness, so Inform is important.” Say “only 19% of the target audience mentioned the brand without prompting, which means the vast majority of the target has never encountered the brand, making Inform the prerequisite for every other task.”

Common error: treating all four DRIP tasks as equally valid and listing them in order without arguing for a clear priority.

ELM: Elaboration Likelihood Model

ELM questions ask you to diagnose the audience's processing style and recommend a communication approach that matches it. There are two common misapplications.

The first common misapplication is staying at the level of labels. “The audience is low-involvement so they will use the peripheral route. Therefore we should use peripheral cues.” This is correct but empty. A strong answer explains what peripheral processing means for this audience in this category: what cues will work, why the existing approach fails to match the processing style, and what a revised approach would look like in concrete terms.

The second common misapplication is treating the central and peripheral routes as mutually exclusive. In reality, the same consumer can process different messages through

different routes depending on their involvement at that moment, their familiarity with the category, and the complexity of the content. For a high-involvement purchase, a consumer who is not yet ready to decide may respond to peripheral cues initially, then seek out central-route content when they move closer to purchase. The best answers acknowledge this complexity.

The ELM also connects directly to creative strategy. Central route processing favors argument quality, evidence, comparison, detail, and message complexity. Peripheral route processing favors source attractiveness, social proof, repetition, simple emotional cues, and association. When recommending a campaign approach, naming the route is only the first step.

Specifying what the creative should contain, and why, is what gets you to B and A. Connection to other frameworks: ELM links directly to FCB matrix quadrant logic, to USP versus ESP strategy, to Strong versus Weak theory, and to the choice between brand building and activation in Binet and Field terms. When these frameworks point in the same direction for a given case, make that alignment explicit.

Strong Theory and Weak Theory

Most exam questions that ask about Strong versus Weak theory are asking you to diagnose which theory better describes how advertising is likely to work in this specific category and for this specific brand situation, and to explain the mechanism behind your answer.

The diagnostic question is: are you trying to change behavior among people who have no current preference for your brand, or are you trying to maintain behavior among people who already buy you?

If the case data shows low awareness, low trial, or a new product entering an unconvinced market, the Strong theory is more applicable. If the case data shows an established brand with high satisfaction among repeat buyers, the Weak theory's reinforcement logic is more relevant.

High-involvement, infrequent purchases (home security, cars, financial products, major appliances) require the Strong theory because there is no habit to reinforce. The consumer is making an active decision, often for the first time, and advertising needs to actually change their mind. Low-involvement, frequently purchased categories are better described by the Weak theory because purchase is habitual and advertising's primary job is salience maintenance.

Common error: describing both theories and concluding that 'both have some relevance.' This is a hedge, not an argument. The question asks you to take a position. Take one, justify it with the case data, and acknowledge the limits of your position if appropriate.

SOV, SOM, and the Investment/Profit-Taking Brand Distinction

The terms investment brand and profit-taking brand are the labels the exam uses for the SOV/SOM relationship. Know these terms precisely.

An investment brand has SOV above SOM. It is spending more on advertising relative to its market share than the category average. Empirically, brands in this position tend to grow market share over time because they are building mental availability at a pace that outstrips their current size. This is the appropriate posture for a growth-stage brand or a brand entering a new market.

A profit-taking brand has SOV below SOM. It is spending less on advertising than its market share position would warrant. In the short term this protects margins. In the medium term it erodes mental availability and market share. Cutting advertising budgets while maintaining revenue targets is the classic profit-taking move. It typically looks like a good decision for one to two years and like a serious strategic error over a five-year period.

When applying this to a case, calculate or estimate the relationship between the brand's budget share and its market share. If a brand has 2% market share and a small absolute budget in a competitive category, they are almost certainly at or below SOV parity, meaning they are at best maintaining and more likely losing ground. Connect this to Binet and Field by explaining that the activation-heavy budget split compounds the problem: all the spend is harvesting existing demand rather than building future demand.

Common error: describing SOV and SOM correctly but not committing to whether the brand is investing or profit-taking. The question is asking for a diagnosis, ergo diagnose.

Binet and Field: 60:40 Rule

Any exam question that asks for 'pros and cons' of the 60:40 rule is asking you to demonstrate that you understand both the strength of the evidence and its limitations. Do not only present the rule as correct. Do not only critique it. Present both sides and let your application to the specific case drive your conclusion.

The strength of the evidence: the IPA Databank is the largest repository of real-world effectiveness data in the industry. The directional finding that over-investment in activation at the expense of brand building reduces long-term effectiveness is robust and replicated. The mechanism is well-understood: brand building creates mental availability and positive associations that make activation more efficient, so cutting brand building raises the cost of every activation-driven sale over time.

The limitations: the data is dominated by large, established brands with significant TV budgets in traditional FMCG categories. The 60:40 ratio is calibrated for brands maintaining or growing market share, not for a new brand that first needs to establish basic awareness. Digital channels blur the brand-building versus activation distinction because the same platform can serve both purposes. The ratio is also harder to defend internally when brand-building effects are slow and diffuse while activation effects are immediately measurable.

For a case involving a small, growth-stage, digital-native brand, the appropriate answer is: the directional principle is sound (brand building matters and cannot be cut indefinitely), but the specific 60:40 ratio may not apply at this stage. A brand with very low awareness may need to invest more heavily in awareness-building before activation can be efficient, which could temporarily reverse the ratio. The key insight is that activation without brand building creates diminishing returns over time.

Recall vs. Recognition: Reliability and Validity

The exam tests not only what these tests measure but the measurement properties of reliability and validity. Recall tests are reliable (consistent) but have lower predictive validity for sales, particularly for emotional advertising. Recognition tests have lower reliability but higher predictive validity, especially for image-based and feel-oriented campaigns.

The practical application: the choice between recall and recognition should follow from the creative strategy. If the campaign uses emotional, atmospheric, ESP-oriented content (peripheral route, feel quadrant of FCB), recall tests will systematically undervalue it. Use recognition. If the campaign is information-dense, rational, and USP-oriented (central route, think quadrant), recall tests are appropriate.

The 3Ps: Pull, Push, and Profile

Pull, push, and profile are not three alternative strategies. They are three simultaneous orientations that almost every organization needs to manage, each directed at a different audience with different goals.

Pull is directed at end-users to create consumer demand. Push is directed at trade channel intermediaries to secure distribution and shelf placement. Profile is directed at broader stakeholders (investors, regulators, media, community) to build organizational reputation. The exam tests your ability to specify the right tool for each orientation. Pull tools are those that reach consumers: advertising, digital content, influencer campaigns, consumer sampling, consumer promotions. Push tools reach the trade: trade allowances, personal selling presentations, cooperative advertising, dealer incentives. Profile tools reach stakeholders: PR, CSR communications, corporate advertising, sustainability reporting, investor relations.

A common error is conflating pull and profile. PR that generates media coverage of a product launch has pull effects (it creates consumer demand) but is a profile tool (it works through third-party editorial channels rather than direct consumer communication). When a question asks you to label a tool, consider the primary audience, not just the effect.

For cases involving expansion into new channels (e.g., entering electronics retail), the push strategy becomes strategically critical and is often underdeveloped in answers. Retailers need to be convinced that stocking the product will be profitable for them. The communication tools for this are fundamentally different from consumer advertising: margin data, sell-through rates, category growth evidence, in-store support materials, and trade presentations. Do not neglect push when the case clearly requires it.

SECTION 3: HOW TO PREPARE USING ONLY THE STUDY GUIDE AND SLIDES

The Resource Situation

You basically need two resources: the Complete Study Guide (the primary source) and lecture slides (secondary, for examples and emphasis signals). The textbook adds depth and examples that are useful for understanding, but the exam does not test textbook knowledge that is not also in the study guide.

How to Use the Study Guide

Do not read the study guide the way you would read a textbook for an information recall exam. The exam is not testing recall of definitions. It is testing application. Reading each definition once and moving on will not prepare you adequately.

For each major framework, you need to be able to do the following from memory:

- State the core claim of the framework in one or two sentences.
- Identify the diagnostic question the framework is designed to answer.
- Describe what a strong versus weak application of the framework looks like.
- Name at least two other frameworks it connects to and explain the connection.
- Give an example of a specific type of case data that would change your application of the framework.

The last two points are the ones most likely to be skipped. Connections between frameworks and sensitivity to case data are exactly what distinguish A and B answers from C answers. Build these explicitly into your revision.

Time Allocation During the Exam

The exam allocates weight explicitly: Task 1A (25%), Task 1B (25%), Task 2 (50%). Allocate your time accordingly. A common failure is spending too much time on Task 1 because it feels more structured and leaving too little time for Task 2, which carries half the grade.

For Task 2, allocate time across the eight sub-questions roughly in proportion to their complexity. Sub-questions a, c, f, g, and h typically require less space than b, d, and especially e. Sub-question e (the MarCom mix) is the heaviest and most substantive part of the campaign response. Do not underdevelop it.

Before writing anything in Task 2, spend some time outlining your general responses. Leave time to check internal coherence before you finish. Read your Task 2 objectives, then read your evaluation section. Do they match? Read your story, then read your ethics section. Does the ethics section address the specific tensions raised by your story?

Four Important things grading-wise

1. Generic = C. Every sentence you write should be answerable only for the specific case in front of you. If it could apply to any organization, rewrite it.
2. Use case data explicitly. Name the numbers. Connect them to the frameworks. “The 11% awareness figure indicates the brand is at the salience level of Keller's pyramid” is better than 'awareness is low.'
3. Frameworks drive choices, they do not label them. Do not write your answer and then add framework names to decorate it. Start from the framework's diagnostic question and let it generate your answer.
4. Task 2 coherence is very important. Check that your objectives, story, mix, and evaluation connect. An incoherent campaign plan with correct individual parts usually scores a C.